The Complete Design Guide: Principles, Evidence and AI Guardrails

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This guide is the governing standard for any visual that leaves this studio, whether a person or an AI model (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude) makes it. Clarity comes first, hierarchy second, consistency third; aesthetics serve the message and never hide it.

0. How to use this guide

Scope. Static graphics, carousels, motion and video, print, presentations, brand identity, web and app screens, and AI-generated imagery. Sections 1–2 explain why design works; sections 3–16 set the rules; section 17 is the guardrail system for AI output; sections 18–20 cover process, delivery and quality control.

How rules are graded.

Grade	Meaning	Example
MUST	A breach fails the design, whatever its other scores	Text contrast below 4.5:1 for body copy
SHOULD	Default practice; break it only for a stated reason	One or two type families per piece
MAY	A good option, used by judgement	A third display face for a campaign accent

Evidence levels. Each rule rests on one of three kinds of support, marked where it matters:

- **[Research]** peer-reviewed findings in perception, cognition, readability or colour science.
- **[Standard]** formal standards: WCAG 2.2, ISO 12647 (print), platform specifications, law and advertising codes.
- **[Practice]** settled professional craft (Swiss grid tradition, typographic convention) that has no single study behind it but near-universal agreement among practitioners.

For AI models. When you are asked to create or edit a visual, treat every MUST in this guide as a hard constraint, state the brief back before generating, spell every word exactly as supplied, invent no facts, figures, logos or emblems, and run the section 17 verification protocol on your own output before presenting it.

For human designers. Read sections 1–2 once, keep sections 3–16 as reference, and run section 20 on every deliverable. Where the brand guideline conflicts with this guide, the brand guideline wins on identity (colour, type, logo) and this guide wins on legibility, accuracy and accessibility.

The order of judgement. When rules pull against each other, resolve them in this order: (1) truth and legality, (2) legibility and accessibility, (3) hierarchy and message, (4) brand consistency, (5) aesthetic preference.

1. Perception and cognition: why design works

Viewers judge a visual's appeal in about 50 milliseconds, and simple, familiar-looking layouts win that judgement. Every rule later in this guide follows from a handful of findings about how eyes and brains process images.

1.1 First impressions are near-instant and stable

- Lindgaard and colleagues showed web pages for 50 ms; appeal ratings at 50 ms closely matched ratings made after longer viewing (Behaviour & Information Technology, 2006, reported by bit-tech). **[Research]**
- Tuch et al. cut exposure to 17 ms. Pages with **low visual complexity and high prototypicality** (they look like what the viewer expects that kind of page to look like) were rated most appealing; complexity is judged first, prototypicality catches up within about half a second (IJHCS 70(11), 2012). **[Research]**
- **Rule (SHOULD):** reduce clutter before adding polish, and respect the genre conventions of the format (a property listing should look like a property listing) unless breaking them is the point.

1.2 Processing fluency: easy to process feels beautiful and true

Reber, Schwarz and Winkielman argue that "the more fluently the perceiver can process an object, the more positive is his or her aesthetic response" (Personality and Social Psychology Review 8(4), 2004). **[Research]** Fluency rises with:

- **Less information** (more redundancy, fewer competing elements).
- **Symmetry**, especially vertical symmetry.
- **Figure–ground contrast and clarity.**
- **Repetition and familiarity** (the mere-exposure effect), which is why consistent series styling builds liking over time.
- **Prototypicality** (looking like a good example of its category).

Design implication: legibility is not only an accessibility issue; harder-to-read designs are also judged less attractive and less credible.

1.3 Gestalt grouping: the eye organises before it reads

The Gestalt principles, reviewed after a century of research by Wagemans et al. (Psychological Bulletin 138(6), 2012), describe how viewers group elements without effort. **[Research]**

Principle	What viewers do	Design use
Proximity	Treat close items as one group; grouping strength falls off steeply with distance	Space between groups must be clearly larger than space within them (at least 2:1)
Similarity	Group items that share colour, shape, size or weight	Give every item of the same kind identical styling
Common region	Group items inside the same boundary	Use cards, panels or tinted backgrounds to bind content
Connectedness	Group items joined by lines	Use connecting lines for steps and flows
Good continuation	Follow smooth lines and curves	Align elements along a clear axis to lead the eye
Closure	Complete incomplete shapes	Allows minimal icons and logos; never rely on it for critical information
Figure–ground	Separate an object from its background	Keep strong contrast between text and what sits behind it
Symmetry	See symmetrical regions as figures	Use symmetry for stability and formality
Common fate	Group things that move together	In motion design, animate related items together

1.4 Attention follows salience, then goals

- Visual salience (contrast in colour, size, brightness, motion, isolation) captures attention first; the viewer's task then steers it. The strongest contrast on the canvas should therefore sit on the most important element.

- **Scanning patterns.** Nielsen Norman Group eye-tracking (2006, updated 2017) found an F-shaped scan on unformatted text, plus layer-cake (headings only), spotted (hunting a keyword), marking (eyes fixed while scrolling) and bypassing (skipping repeated first words of list items) patterns (NN/g). The F-pattern is the default "when there are no strong cues"; good hierarchy replaces it. **[Research]**
- **Rule (SHOULD):** front-load headings and list items with the most informative words; never begin every bullet with the same word.

1.5 Cognitive load and choice

- Working memory holds only a few chunks at once (cognitive load theory, Sweller, 1988). Group content into 3–5 chunks and remove anything that does not serve the message. **[Research]**
- Hick's law: decision time grows with the number of options. One primary call to action per piece. **[Research]**
- Fitts's law: targets are faster to hit when larger and closer. Applies to buttons and tap targets (section 14). **[Research]**

1.6 The aesthetic–usability effect

People rate attractive interfaces as easier to use. Kurosu and Kashimura (CHI 1995) found r = 0.59 between perceived aesthetics and apparent usability; Tractinsky, Katz and Ikar replicated it (r = 0.66 before use, 0.71 after) and found that aesthetics, not actual usability, drove post-use ratings (Interacting with Computers 13(2), 2000). **[Research]** Caveat: beauty buys tolerance, not a pass; a beautiful design that hides the message still fails.

1.7 Practical tests derived from the research

1. **Squint or blur test:** the main message and focal point must survive a heavy blur.
2. **Thumbnail test:** view at 20% size; the hierarchy must still read.
3. **Grayscale test:** hierarchy must not depend on colour alone.
4. **Five-second test:** a stranger shown the design for five seconds can state its main message.
5. **Genre test:** it still looks like the kind of thing it is (an invitation, a valuation report, a sale post).

2. Core design principles

Every strong design has one focal point, a clear first-second-third reading order, and elements that visibly belong to one system. The principles below work together; a fix to one usually helps the others.

Principle	MUST / SHOULD rule	How to check
Hierarchy	MUST have a clear first, second and third read; built with size, weight, contrast, position and space, not decoration	Name the reading order in under 5 seconds
Emphasis / focal point	MUST have one dominant focal point unless the brief calls for equal weight	Blur test: one element still stands out
Contrast	SHOULD use large differences (size ratio of at least 2:1 between levels, strong light/dark difference); small differences read as mistakes	Grayscale test
Alignment	MUST align every element to an edge, axis, baseline or grid line	Draw guides; nothing floats
Proximity	MUST group related items and separate unrelated ones; gap between groups at least twice the gap within	Can you circle each group?
Repetition	SHOULD repeat styles for the same kind of content (labels, icons, cards, bullets)	Same-role items look identical
Balance	SHOULD distribute visual weight on purpose: symmetrical (formal, stable), asymmetrical (dynamic), radial (focus)	Does one side feel heavy with no reason?
Scale and proportion	SHOULD size by importance, using a consistent ratio (see 3.4 and 4.4)	No arbitrary in-between sizes
Whitespace	MUST keep margins and breathing room; whitespace is active, not empty	Does anything touch an edge or neighbour?
Rhythm	SHOULD space repeated items at regular intervals	Equal gaps between equal items
Movement / flow	SHOULD lead the eye from hook to message to call to action	Trace the eye path; it ends at the CTA
Unity	MUST make all elements feel like one system (colour, type, shape, tone)	Remove the logo: still one family?

Principle	MUST / SHOULD rule	How to check
Variety	MAY vary within the system to avoid monotony; never at random	Variation is deliberate and repeated

2.1 Visual weight: what makes an element heavy

Visual weight rises with **size, darkness, saturation, contrast, complexity, isolation, faces and eyes, text with meaning, and position** (elements high or to the right feel heavier in left-to-right cultures). Balance a large pale area with a small dark or saturated one. **[Practice; perception research]**

2.2 Common failure patterns

- **Everything is important:** many bold, large or coloured items cancel each other out. Pick one hero.
- **Near misses:** elements almost aligned or almost the same size look like errors. Make things clearly the same or clearly different.
- **Equal spacing everywhere:** removes grouping. Vary space deliberately to show structure.
- **Decoration as hierarchy:** boxes, badges and shadows used instead of size and contrast. Remove them and fix the hierarchy.
- **Competing focal points:** a strong photo, a big number and a loud badge all fighting. Subordinate two of them.

3. Composition, layout and grids

Build every layout on a grid and a spacing scale, keep critical content inside a safe area, and give the canvas one dominant composition. Numbers make these rules checkable.

3.1 Grids

Grid type	Best for	Notes
Manuscript (single column)	Long text, letters, reports	Wide margins, one measure
Column (2–12 columns)	Websites, magazines, flyers, social graphics	12 columns divides into 2, 3, 4 and 6; 4 columns on phones
Modular (rows × columns)	Catalogues, dashboards, infographics, carousels	Cells hold images or text blocks

Grid type	Best for	Notes
Hierarchical	Posters, landing pages	Zones sized by importance rather than equal modules
Baseline grid	Multi-column text	All text sits on a shared baseline (multiples of 4 or 8)

Rules: every major element SHOULD snap to the grid; gutters MUST be consistent; break the grid only deliberately and only once per piece (a hero image bleeding off the edge, say). **[Practice: Swiss tradition, Müller-Brockmann]**

3.2 Spacing scale

- Use a base unit of **8 px** (4 px for fine adjustments): 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48, 64, 96, 128. This is the system used by Google's Material Design and most digital design systems. **[Standard/Practice]**
- Space inside a group < space between groups < space between sections. A useful default is 1 : 2 : 4 (e.g. 16 / 32 / 64 px).
- On a 1080 px social canvas, outer margins SHOULD be at least 64 px (about 6%); 80–108 px (7.5–10%) reads as more premium.

3.3 Safe areas and margins

- **MUST:** keep text, logos, faces and calls to action out of the outer 5% of any canvas, and out of platform overlay zones (section 11).
- For print, keep live content at least 3–5 mm inside the trim line (section 13).
- For video, title-safe is the central 80–90% of the frame; platform interface overlays take more (section 12).

3.4 Proportion and ratios

- Use a consistent ratio for sizes and spaces (1.25, 1.333, 1.5, 1.618 or 2). Consistency matters more than which ratio you pick.
- **The golden ratio is a tool, not a law.** Controlled experiments have not found a reliable preference for golden proportions; Friedenberg found attractiveness "did not peak at the golden ratio" and compactness mattered more (i-Perception 3(3), 2012). Never justify a design by claiming it follows phi. **[Research]**
- **Rule of thirds:** place focal points near the intersections of a 3 × 3 grid for dynamic photo crops; centre composition suits symmetry, formality and single-subject product shots. **[Practice]**

3.5 Zones and reading paths

- Divide the canvas into zones with one job each: hook (headline), proof (image or data), detail (supporting copy), action (CTA or sign-off).
- **Z-pattern** suits sparse layouts (posters, ads): top-left → top-right → diagonal → bottom-right CTA. **F-pattern** governs text-heavy layouts (section 1.4).
- Text-heavy panel on one side and image on the other is a strong default for social graphics; alternate sides across a series for variety.

3.6 Precision rules

- **Tangencies (MUST avoid):** edges, text and subjects must either clearly overlap or clearly separate; near-touching reads as an error.
- **Cropping:** never crop at joints (wrists, ankles, knees, neck) or through the middle of a face or product; leave look-room in front of faces and moving subjects.
- **Optical alignment:** round letters (O, C), pointed shapes (triangles, play icons) and punctuation need to overhang edges slightly to look aligned; centre icons optically, not mathematically.
- **Optical sizing:** circles and triangles must be drawn slightly larger than squares to look the same size.
- **Hanging punctuation:** in display type, quotation marks and bullets sit outside the text edge so the letters align.
- **Edge discipline:** an element either sits clearly inside the margin or bleeds clearly off the canvas; never stop 2 mm short of an edge.

4. Typography

Type is information architecture: use one or two families, a fixed size scale, comfortable line length and spacing, and sizes that survive the real viewing distance. Most amateur work fails on size and spacing, not font choice.

4.1 Anatomy and classification (vocabulary you must share)

- **Anatomy:** baseline, x-height, cap height, ascender, descender, counter, stroke contrast, terminal, serif.
- **Classes:** serif (old-style, transitional, modern/Didone, slab), sans-serif (grotesque, neo-grotesque, humanist, geometric), script, display/decorative, monospace.
- **x-height drives legibility.** Two fonts at the same point size can differ in apparent size by 20% or more; compare x-heights, not point sizes. Legge and Bigelow's review of vision science and typography found reading is fastest across a fluent range of sizes

above a “critical print size”, and that most print and screen text sits near the bottom of that range (Journal of Vision 11(5), 2011). Err larger. **[Research]**

4.2 Choosing and pairing typefaces

- **SHOULD:** one family for most work, two at most (a display face plus a text face); a third only for a deliberate accent.
- Pair by **contrast in one dimension** (serif with sans, or condensed with regular) and **harmony in others** (similar x-height, era or proportions).
- Choose families with a full weight range (at least regular, medium, bold), true italics, and complete glyph coverage. **MUST** check special characters before committing: ₦ (naira), €, £, –, —, curly quotes, and accented letters for Yoruba, Igbo and Hausa (ẹ, ọ, ṣ, à, á, ǹ, ɓ, ɗ, ḱ).
- Screen text: favour faces with large x-height, open apertures and clear letter differentiation (I, l, 1; O, 0; rn vs m).
- Display faces and scripts are for a few words only, never body copy.

4.3 Size: minimums by medium

Medium	Body / supporting text	Headline	Notes
Web page	16 px minimum, 18–20 px preferred	32–64 px	Never below 12 px for any visible text
Mobile app	16–17 px body	22–34 px	Respect system text-size settings
Social post, 1080 px wide canvas	28–36 px minimum (about 2.6–3.3% of width)	72–140 px	Seen at roughly a third of its size on a phone
Presentation (16:9, 1920 px)	24 pt / 32 px minimum	40–60 pt	One idea per slide
Print document (A4)	9–12 pt	18–36 pt	8 pt absolute floor for legal small print
Flyer (A5/A4)	10–14 pt	36–72 pt	Read at arm’s length
Poster / signage	2.5 cm cap height per 7–10 m of viewing distance	—	Rule of thumb for distance legibility

Rule (MUST): if text must shrink below these minimums to fit, cut the copy (section 8), never the size.

4.4 Type scale

- Define 4–6 levels: display, headline, subhead, body, caption, label. Each level differs from its neighbour by a clear ratio.
- Common ratios: 1.25 (major third, dense UIs), 1.333 (perfect fourth, general), 1.5 (perfect fifth, editorial), 1.618 (golden, posters). Example at 1.333 from 16 px: 16 / 21 / 28 / 38 / 50 / 67.
- For social graphics a steep scale works best: headline at least 2.5× body size.

4.5 Line length (measure)

- **SHOULD:** 45–75 characters per line for body text (66 ideal for print); 30–50 on mobile and in social graphics.
- Dyson's reviews found people read on-screen text slightly faster at long lines (around 100 characters) but **prefer** 45–72 characters (summary, O'Reilly). Design for comfort and comprehension, not raw speed. **[Research]**

4.6 Leading (line spacing)

- Body text: 1.4–1.6 × font size (WCAG 2.2 requires layouts to survive 1.5×; section 10).
- Headlines and display: 1.0–1.2 ×. Tight, but ascenders and descenders must never touch.
- Longer lines need more leading; all-caps needs less.
- Paragraph spacing: about 0.75–1.0 × the font size, or first-line indents, never both.

4.7 Tracking and kerning

- All-caps and small labels: +5% to +12% tracking (50–120 units).
- Large display type: −1% to −3% (tighter); body text: 0.
- Check kerning on display type manually: AV, To, Wa, LT, Ty and number pairs.
- **MUST NOT** stretch, squash, skew or fake bold/italic type.

4.8 Case and capitalisation

- Lowercase text is read about 5–10% faster than ALL CAPS, mainly because readers practise it more (Larson, Microsoft Research, 2005). Use caps for short labels and headings only, never paragraphs. **[Research]**
- Pick one system per level (sentence case for headlines, caps for labels, for example) and never mix within a level.
- UK English house style (Crea8Hub and Nigerian professional clients): sentence case headlines, single quotation marks, -ise spellings, dates as 9 November 2026.

4.9 Alignment of text

- **Flush left / ragged right** is the default for body text in left-to-right languages.
- Centred text: 1–3 lines only (titles, invitations, quotes).
- Justified text: only with hyphenation and good word-spacing control; never on narrow columns (rivers of white).
- Right-aligned text: for short captions or numbers in tables only.

4.10 Line breaks, widows and orphans

- Break display lines by meaning ("5 things I check / during a rent review"), not by width.
- No single word alone on the last line of a headline or short paragraph; no single line of a paragraph alone at the top or bottom of a column.
- Avoid ragged edges with strong steps (long-short-long); rebalance.
- Never break a name, a number and its unit (₦12 m), or a date across lines.

4.11 Typographic details that signal professionalism

- Curly quotes (‘ ’ “ ”) and apostrophes, not straight ones; primes (′ ″) only for feet and inches.
- En dash for ranges (₦12–18 m, 9–15 Nov); em dash or spaced en dash for breaks; hyphen only inside words.
- Proper multiplication sign (×), ellipsis (…), and non-breaking spaces between numbers and units.
- **Numerals:** tabular (fixed-width) figures in tables and prices; proportional figures in running text; old-style figures only in literary settings.
- Bold and italic for emphasis, never underline (reserved for links), never several at once.
- Text over images needs a scrim, overlay or solid panel to guarantee contrast (section 5.6).

5. Colour

Build a small, named palette with one dominant colour, check every text pairing against WCAG contrast, never carry meaning by colour alone, and treat colour-psychology claims with caution: colour meaning is real but depends heavily on context and culture.

5.1 Colour science essentials

- **Additive (RGB)** colour is light: screens, mixing to white. **Subtractive (CMYK)** colour is ink: print, mixing towards black. Screen colours, especially bright greens, oranges and blues, often cannot be printed (out of gamut).
- **Three dimensions:** hue (the colour family), saturation or chroma (intensity), and value or lightness (how light or dark). Hierarchy depends mostly on **value**; that is why the grayscale test works.
- **Colour spaces:** sRGB (web and social default), Display P3 (wider, modern phones and Macs), Adobe RGB (photography), CMYK profiles such as FOGRA39/51 or GRACoL (print), CIELAB and **OKLCH** (perceptually uniform).
- **Use OKLCH or LAB to build palettes.** HSL is not perceptually uniform: a yellow and a blue at the same HSL lightness look very different. Oklab/OKLCH (Ottosson, 2020) fixes this, gives smoother gradients and tint ramps, and is supported in CSS Color 4 (Wikipedia summary). **[Standard]**
- **Simultaneous contrast:** a colour looks different depending on its neighbours (Albers, *Interaction of Color*). Always judge colour in the final composition and on the target device.

5.2 Building a palette

Role	Share of visual area	Notes
Dominant (often a neutral or brand base)	~60%	Backgrounds, large fields
Secondary	~30%	Panels, cards, supporting shapes
Accent	~10% or less	Calls to action, key numbers, labels; if everything is accent, nothing is
Neutrals	As needed	Text, dividers; tint them slightly towards the brand hue rather than pure grey
Functional	Sparingly	Success, warning, error; never reuse the brand accent for error states

- The 60-30-10 split is a **[Practice]** starting point, not a law.
- Build each colour as a ramp of 9–11 steps (e.g. 50–950) of equal perceptual lightness steps, so tints and shades stay consistent.

- **Avoid pure black (#000) on pure white** for long text on screens; use a very dark neutral (e.g. #14213D-like navies or #1A1A1A) to reduce glare while keeping contrast high.
- Limit fully saturated colours to one or two; saturation competes for attention.

5.3 Harmony schemes

Scheme	Construction	Character	Use
Monochromatic	One hue, varied lightness and chroma	Calm, cohesive, premium	Corporate, luxury, minimal
Analogous	Neighbouring hues (within ~30–60°)	Natural, harmonious	Lifestyle, wellness
Complementary	Opposite hues	High energy, strong contrast	Calls to action, sport, sales
Split-complementary	Base + two neighbours of its complement	Contrast with less tension	General marketing
Triadic	Three hues 120° apart	Playful, vivid	Children, entertainment; mute two of them
Navy + warm accent (e.g. navy and coral)	Dark cool base + one warm accent	Trustworthy yet approachable	Professional services, finance, property

5.4 Colour psychology: what the evidence supports

- **Associations are real and largely shared across cultures.** A 30-nation study of 4,598 people, including Nigerian participants, found colour–emotion patterns in each country correlated r = .88 with the global pattern: black with sadness, fear and hate; red with love and anger; yellow and orange with joy; pink with love and pleasure; grey with sadness; white with relief. Language and geography shaped the remaining differences (Jonauskaite et al., Psychological Science 31(10), 2020). **[Research]**
- **Preferences track the objects colours remind us of.** Palmer and Schloss's ecological valence theory explained 80% of variance in colour preference by the appeal of objects with those colours: blues (clear sky, clean water) liked; browns and olive yellows (decay) disliked; saturated colours preferred to muted (PNAS 107(19), 2010). **[Research]**

- **Colour shapes brand personality.** Labrecque and Milne showed hue, saturation and value shift perceived brand personality and purchase intent ("exciting red and competent blue") (Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science 40, 2012). **[Research]**
- **But effects are context-dependent and the field is young.** Elliot's review calls colour psychology "at a nascent stage of development" and urges "patience and prudence" before applying findings (Frontiers in Psychology 6:368, 2015). Red can signal danger in an exam setting and attraction in a dating setting. **[Research]**
- **Zombie statistic warning:** the widely quoted claim that "62–90% of product judgements are based on colour alone" appears in Singh (2006) without any citation or supporting data (Management Decision 44(6)). **MUST NOT** be quoted as fact.

Working associations (use as hypotheses, test with your audience):

Colour	Common associations	Watch out for
Navy / dark blue	Trust, competence, stability, finance, professional services	Can feel cold or generic without a warm accent
Light blue	Calm, health, clean, technology	Low contrast with white text
Red	Energy, urgency, love, danger, appetite	Overuse reads as alarm; error states
Coral / warm orange	Approachable, friendly, optimistic	Fails contrast as small text on white
Yellow / gold	Joy, optimism, value; gold for premium	Yellow text on white is illegible; mustard/olive tones disliked
Green	Growth, money, health, sustainability; Nigerian national colour	Red-green pairs fail for colour-blind viewers
Purple	Luxury, creativity, royalty	Can feel dated if over-saturated
Black	Luxury, authority, sophistication; mourning	Heavy if dominant on small screens
White	Purity, cleanliness, simplicity; worn at some Nigerian funerals and religious events	Needs structure or it feels unfinished
Brown / earth	Natural, reliable, rustic	Least-liked hue family in preference studies

5.5 Colour in the Nigerian context

- In Yoruba, Igbo and Hausa symbolism, **white** signals purity, holiness and sincerity (and is worn at some funerals); **red** signals power, danger, passion and is linked to thunder deities; **black** signals mourning and negative forces (Adédínà and Táíwò, LASU Journal of African Studies 8, 2020). **[Research]**
- **Green and white** carry strong national (and often political or patriotic) associations; use them deliberately, and avoid party colours in neutral commercial work during election periods.
- Aso-ebi and celebration contexts favour bold, saturated, metallic palettes; corporate and professional services favour navy, deep green, gold accents.

5.6 Contrast and accessibility (MUST)

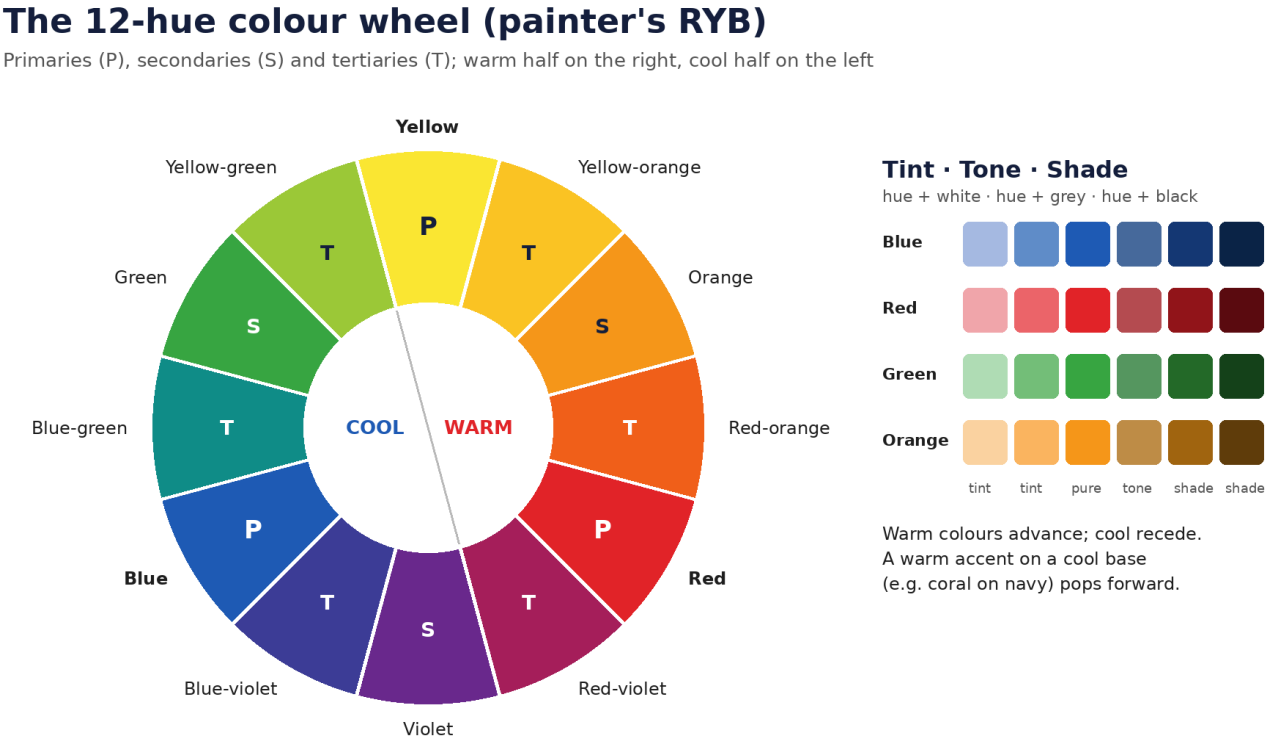
- **WCAG 2.2 SC 1.4.3 (AA):** body text at least **4.5:1** against its background; large text (at least 18 pt / 24 px, or 14 pt / 18.5 px bold) at least **3:1**. Ratios are not rounded: 4.499:1 fails. Logos are exempt. Enhanced (AAA) is **7:1** (W3C). **[Standard]**
- **SC 1.4.11:** icons, chart elements, input borders and buttons at least **3:1** against adjacent colours. **[Standard]**
- **Text over photographs:** guarantee contrast with a solid panel, a gradient scrim (typically 40–70% black or brand-dark), or a blurred, darkened area; check the worst spot of the image, not the average.
- **Colour-vision deficiency:** about 8% of men and 0.5% of women of Northern European ancestry have red-green deficiency; in Lagos State a study of 2,326 students found **4.8% of males and 0.7% of females** affected (Oduntan et al., African Health Sciences 19(2), 2019). **[Research]** MUST NOT rely on red vs green alone; add labels, icons, patterns or position. Simulate deuteranopia and protanopia before approval.

5.7 Colour management

- Design social and web in **sRGB**; export JPG/PNG with the sRGB profile embedded so colours do not shift between apps.
- Print: convert to the printer's CMYK profile, soft-proof first, and expect bright RGB colours to dull. Specify Pantone (PMS) for logos and brand colours that must match exactly.
- Calibrate monitors for colour-critical work; check final pieces on at least one phone, since most social content is seen there.
- Write brand colours in all needed formats: HEX, RGB, CMYK, Pantone, and OKLCH.

5.8 The colour wheel

The colour wheel arranges hues in a circle so relationships between them can be seen and used: colours opposite each other contrast most, neighbours harmonise, and the wheel splits into a warm half and a cool half.



Two wheels, two purposes. The traditional painter's wheel (RYB: red, yellow, blue primaries) is the one taught in art and used for most colour-harmony rules. The light wheel (RGB primaries red, green, blue; complements cyan, magenta, yellow) describes how screens and printing actually mix colour. Use the RYB wheel to choose pleasing combinations; use RGB/CMYK and OKLCH values to produce them accurately (section 5.1).

Level	Colours (RYB wheel)	How they are made
Primary	Red, yellow, blue	Cannot be mixed from other paints
Secondary	Orange, green, violet	Two primaries mixed
Tertiary	Red-orange, yellow-orange, yellow-green, blue-green, blue-violet, red-violet	A primary mixed with a neighbouring secondary

Warm and cool. Reds, oranges and yellows (and their browns) read as warm: energetic, near, appetising, friendly. Blues, greens and violets read as cool: calm, distant, trustworthy, clean. Warm colours appear to advance and cool colours to recede, so a warm

accent on a cool base pops forward naturally (the navy-and-coral pairing works for this reason).

Tints, tones and shades. Every hue has a family:

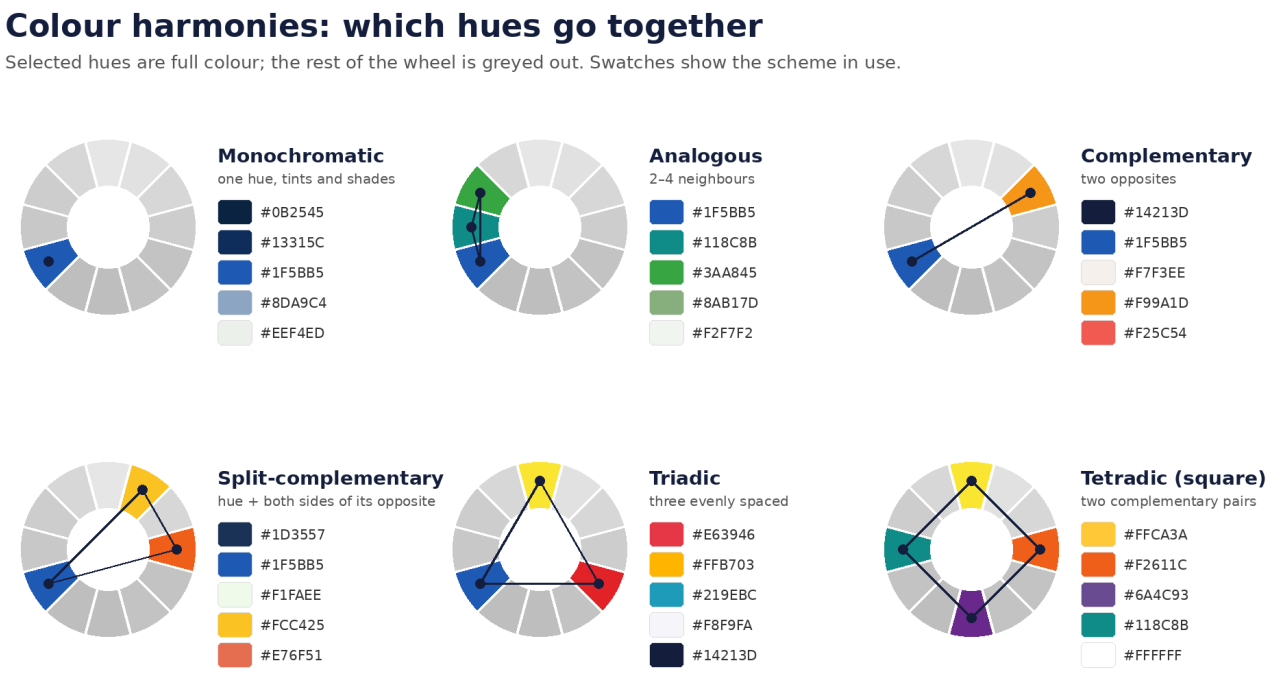
- **Tint** = hue + white (lighter, softer: pastels, backgrounds).
- **Tone** = hue + grey (muted, sophisticated, calm).
- **Shade** = hue + black (deeper, richer, more serious: navy, maroon, forest green).

Most professional palettes are built from tones and shades plus one pure accent, not from several fully saturated hues.

5.9 Colour harmonies with ready examples

Harmony	On the wheel	Example palette (HEX)	Feels	Watch out
Monochromatic	One hue, many tints and shades	#0B2545 · #13315C · #134074 · #8DA9C4 · #EEF4ED	Calm, premium, cohesive	Can go flat; add contrast in value
Analogous	2–4 neighbours	#264653 · #2A9D8F · #8AB17D · #E9C46A	Natural, harmonious	Low contrast; pick one to dominate
Complementary	Two opposites	#14213D (navy) + #F25C54 (coral) or #FCA311 (amber)	Energetic, high impact	Never use both at full strength in equal amounts; edges “vibrate”
Split-complementary	One hue + the two neighbours of its opposite	#1D3557 · #E63946 · #F4A261	Lively but balanced	Keep one dominant
Triadic	Three hues evenly spaced	#E63946 · #FFB703 · #219EBC	Playful, vivid	Mute two of the three
Tetradic / square	Four hues (two complementary pairs)	#6A4C93 · #1982C4 · #8AC926 · #FFCA3A	Rich, festive	Hardest to balance; one dominant, others small

Harmony	On the wheel	Example palette (HEX)	Feels	Watch out
Neutral + accent	Greys or beiges + one colour	#111111 · #F1EFE9 · #84C226	Modern, confident	Accent only on what matters



5.10 What goes with what: pairing guide

Base colour	Pairs well with	Avoid pairing with	Good for
Navy	Coral, amber, gold, white, cream, light grey, sky blue	Black (muddy), dark purple	Finance, law, property, consulting
Black	White, cream, gold, one bright accent (lime, red, electric blue)	Dark navy or brown (low contrast)	Luxury, fashion, tech, creative agencies
White / off-white	Almost anything; especially navy, black, forest green, terracotta	Yellow and pale pastels as text	Clean, healthcare, minimal brands

Base colour	Pairs well with	Avoid pairing with	Good for
Red	White, black, navy, cream, gold	Green at equal strength (clash, colour-blind fail), pink, orange side by side	Sales, food, urgency, celebration
Coral / salmon	Navy, teal, cream, charcoal	Red, bright orange	Friendly professional, lifestyle
Orange	Navy, teal, white, charcoal	Red, brown, pink	Energy, youth, food, telecoms
Yellow / gold	Navy, black, charcoal, deep green, purple	White as background for yellow text; light grey	Optimism, value, premium (gold)
Green (emerald, forest)	Gold, cream, white, navy, blush pink	Red, bright blue at equal strength	Money, growth, health, eco, Nigeria-themed
Lime / bright green	Black, charcoal, white, deep navy	Yellow, orange	Tech, sport, youth
Teal / turquoise	Coral, cream, navy, gold	Green-blue mixes of similar value	Wellness, travel, fintech
Purple	Gold, cream, lavender, grey, green accents	Red, brown	Luxury, beauty, creativity
Pink / blush	Burgundy, navy, gold, sage green, grey	Red, orange at full strength	Beauty, weddings, femtech
Brown / beige / terracotta	Cream, olive, rust, navy, teal	Purple, bright pink	Natural, artisan, real estate interiors
Grey	One saturated accent (yellow, coral, teal), navy	Several other greys of the same value	Corporate, tech, neutral backdrops

5.11 Ready palettes by sector (starting points)

Sector	Palette (dominant · secondary · accent · neutral)	Why it works
Real estate and valuation	#14213D · #2E4A7D · #F25C54 · #F7F3EE	Navy trust and competence, warm accent for approachability

Sector	Palette (dominant · secondary · accent · neutral)	Why it works
Finance and banking	#0B6E4F · #073B3A · #C9A227 · #F5F5F0	Green for money and growth, gold for value
Law and consulting	#1B263B · #415A77 · #B08D57 · #E0E1DD	Serious shades, muted gold for prestige
Healthcare	#005F73 · #0A9396 · #EE9B00 · #F8F9FA	Calm teal, clean white, warm accent for warmth
Food and hospitality	#9B2226 · #CA6702 · #EE9B00 · #FFF8F0	Warm, appetising reds and ambers
Luxury and fashion	#111111 · #3A3A3A · #C9A227 · #F1EFE9	Restraint, black and gold, generous whitespace
Creative agency (e.g. Crea8Hub)	#111111 · #F1EFE9 · #84C226 · #FFFFFF	Neutral base, one confident signature accent
Tech and fintech	#0D1B2A · #1B4965 · #5FA8D3 · #F0F4F8	Cool blues signal reliability and modernity
Education and children	#3A86FF · #FFBE0B · #FB5607 · #FFFFFF	Bright triadic energy; keep text dark
Weddings and aso-ebi celebrations	#6A1B4D · #C9A227 · #F2D7D9 · #FFFDF8	Wine and gold for richness, blush for softness
Eco and agriculture	#386641 · #6A994E · #F2E8CF · #BC4749	Natural greens, earthy cream, small red accent

Always test any palette for contrast (5.12) and against the client's brand guideline, which overrides these suggestions.

5.12 Text and background pairs: what passes

Contrast ratios calculated with the WCAG formula (pass for body text = 4.5:1; large text = 3:1).

Text on background	Ratio	Body text	Large text
White on navy #14213D	15.97:1	Pass	Pass
Off-white #F1EFE9 on near-black #111111	16.42:1	Pass	Pass

Text on background	Ratio	Body text	Large text
Amber #FFD23F on navy #14213D	11.06:1	Pass	Pass
Lime #84C226 on near-black #111111	8.75:1	Pass	Pass
Purple #7B2CBF on white	7.11:1	Pass	Pass
Gold #C9A227 on navy #14213D	6.60:1	Pass	Pass
Coral #F25C54 on navy #14213D	4.89:1	Pass	Pass
Nigerian green #008751 on white	4.58:1	Pass (just)	Pass
Grey #767676 on white	4.54:1	Pass (lightest passing grey)	Pass
Red #E63946 on white	4.17:1	Fail	Pass
Coral #F25C54 on white	3.26:1	Fail	Pass
Gold #C9A227 on white	2.42:1	Fail	Fail
Lime #84C226 on white	2.16:1	Fail	Fail
Yellow #FFD23F on white	1.44:1	Fail	Fail
Pure red #FF0000 on pure green #00FF00	2.91:1	Fail	Fail (and vibrates)

Lesson: bright warm accents (coral, gold, lime, yellow) work on dark backgrounds or as large shapes, not as small text on white.

5.13 Combinations that clash and why

- **Equal-strength complements side by side** (red/green, blue/orange, purple/yellow at full saturation): edges appear to vibrate; reduce one to a shade or tint, or separate them with white or black.
- **Red with green** for meaning (good/bad): fails for about 1 in 20 Nigerian men (section 5.6).
- **Similar values, different hues** (mid-blue on mid-red): looks colourful but disappears in grayscale and is hard to read.
- **Too many saturated colours:** nothing leads; use one saturated accent and neutralise the rest.
- **Pure blue text on black, yellow text on white, neon on neon:** unreadable.
- **Muddy mixes:** brown with purple, olive with grey of the same value; these sit in the least-liked colour families (section 5.4).

5.14 Building a palette in six steps

1. **Start from meaning:** what should the brand or piece feel like (trustworthy, festive, premium)? Pick a base hue family from 5.4 and 5.11.
2. **Choose the dominant colour** (often a shade or neutral) for about 60% of the area.
3. **Choose the accent** from the opposite or split-complementary side of the wheel for contrast; keep it to about 10%.
4. **Add a secondary** from the analogous side of the dominant for about 30%.
5. **Add neutrals:** an off-white and a near-black, tinted slightly towards the dominant hue.
6. **Test:** contrast ratios (5.12), grayscale, colour-blind simulation, phone screen in sunlight, and the client's cultural context (5.5).

6. Imagery, photography, illustration and icons

Every image must earn its place by proving, showing or making the viewer feel the message; it must be sharp, honestly represented, cropped with intent, and consistent with the other images in the set.

6.1 Choosing images

- **Relevance over beauty (MUST):** the image shows the subject, audience or result the copy is about. A lovely but generic image weakens trust.
- **Specific over generic:** real places, real products, real work and real (consenting) people outperform obvious stock. For a Lagos valuer, Lekki, Ikoyi or Abuja streetscapes beat generic Western suburbs.
- **One subject:** a single clear subject with a simple background. Busy images compete with text.
- **Faces attract the eye first.** Use them when the person is the message. A face looking towards the headline guides attention to it (gaze cueing); a face looking out of the frame leads attention away. **[Research: gaze-cueing literature; Practice]**
- **Emotion and action:** people doing the activity convey more than posed portraits.
- **Representation:** show the real audience in age, skin tone, body type, ability and setting. For Nigerian audiences, Nigerian people, dress, architecture and light. Avoid stereotypes and tokenism.

6.2 Quality and resolution

Use	Minimum resolution
Social post (1080 px wide)	Source at least 1080 px on the shortest needed side; 2× (2160 px) preferred
Website hero	2400–3000 px wide, compressed to under 300–500 KB
Print	300 ppi at final printed size (150–200 ppi acceptable for large posters viewed from afar)
Logo	Vector (SVG, EPS, PDF, AI) always

- **MUST NOT** upscale low-resolution images and pass them off as sharp; AI upscalers invent detail and must never be used on products, documents, faces of real people or property features.
- Check for compression artefacts, banding in skies and gradients, noise and soft focus at 100% zoom.

6.3 Image treatment and series consistency

- In a set, keep consistent: lighting direction and time of day, colour grade, crop tightness, background style and camera angle.
- Use one grading approach (warm, cool, high-contrast or natural) per campaign.
- Duotones and colour washes in brand colours unify mixed photography.
- **Overlays:** a gradient or tint should lift text legibility without destroying the photo. Typical values: 30–70% opacity of a dark brand colour, or a directional gradient from the text side.

6.4 Cropping and composition in photos

- Rule of thirds for dynamic crops; centre for symmetry and product shots.
- Leave space in the direction the subject faces or moves.
- Never crop at joints, through the chin or the top of the head at an awkward point, or through a product's label.
- Straighten horizons and vertical lines (architecture especially: correct converging verticals).

6.5 Illustration

- Choose one style (flat, line, isometric, 3D, hand-drawn) and stick to it within a campaign.
- Match line weight, corner radius, palette and level of detail across all illustrations.
- Illustration suits abstract ideas (processes, concepts, data); photography suits trust and proof (real places, real people, real products).

6.6 Icons

- **One icon family (MUST):** same grid (commonly 24 × 24 px), stroke weight (e.g. 1.5 or 2 px), corner style, fill style (outline or solid, not both) and level of detail.
- Icons support labels; they rarely replace them. Pair icons with text for anything critical.
- Use familiar metaphors (house = property, document = report); test unfamiliar ones.
- Icons need 3:1 contrast against their background (section 5.6).
- Size icons relative to the text they accompany: roughly the cap height to 1.5× the line height.

6.7 Photography ethics and authenticity

- Do not retouch body shape or skin in ways that misrepresent; disclose significant retouching in ads where required.
- Property, product and “before and after” images MUST show the real item without hiding defects (section 16).
- Keep model releases for identifiable people and property releases where needed (section 16).

7. Information design and data visualisation

Pick the chart that encodes the key comparison as position or length, start bars at zero, label directly, state the takeaway as the headline, and cite the source on the graphic.

7.1 How accurately people read visual encodings

Cleveland and McGill ranked encodings by how much error people make reading them (Journal of the American Statistical Association 79, 1984). **[Research]** From most to least accurate:

1. Position on a common scale (dot plots, aligned bars)
2. Position on non-aligned scales (small multiples)

3. Length, direction, angle
4. Area
5. Volume, curvature
6. Shading and colour saturation

Consequence: bar and dot charts beat pie charts, bubbles and 3D charts whenever precise comparison matters.

7.2 Choosing the chart

Message	Best chart	Avoid
Compare amounts across items	Horizontal bar chart, sorted	3D bars, pie with many slices
Change over time	Line chart (bars for few periods)	Pies, unevenly spaced dates
Parts of a whole	Stacked bar or 100% bar; pie or donut only for 2–4 slices	Pies with 6+ slices, 3D pies
Before vs after for many items	Slope chart or dumbbell (dot range)	Two separate pies
A range (e.g. ₦12–18 m to ₦40–90 m)	Range bars or dumbbells showing low–high	Single midpoint presented as exact
Distribution	Histogram, box or strip plot	Average alone
Relationship between two measures	Scatter plot	Dual-axis line charts
Contribution to a change	Waterfall	Stacked bars
Location	Choropleth or dot map, normalised per capita	Raw totals on area maps
A single striking number	Big number with context (“up 3× since May 2026”)	A chart with one bar

7.3 Honesty rules (MUST)

- **Bar charts start at zero.** Truncated axes inflate perceived differences, and Correll et al. found visual warnings such as broken axes do not reliably correct the impression (Truncating the Y-Axis: Threat or Menace?, 2020). Line charts may use a non-zero

baseline when the meaningful change is small relative to the level, but say so. **[Research]**

- Area and icons must scale by area, not by height (doubling an icon's height quadruples its area).
- Same units and same scale when charts are compared side by side.
- Show ranges and uncertainty where the data has them; label estimates as estimates ("reported figures").
- Never cherry-pick start and end dates to manufacture a trend.
- Cite the data source and date on the graphic itself.

7.4 Clarity rules

- **Headline states the takeaway** ("Lekki consent fees roughly tripled"), not the topic ("Consent fees 2025–2026").
- Label data directly instead of using legends wherever possible.
- Remove gridlines, borders, shadows and backgrounds that carry no data (Tufte's data-ink principle), but see 7.5.
- Highlight the one series or bar that matters in the accent colour; grey the rest.
- Sort bars by value unless order has meaning (time, age bands).
- Round numbers to the precision the reader needs (₦40 m, not ₦40,183,229).
- Use colour-blind-safe palettes and redundant encoding (labels, patterns).

7.5 Embellishment: when "chartjunk" helps

Bateman et al. found illustrated charts were read as accurately as plain ones and were remembered significantly better two to three weeks later (CHI 2010, "Useful junk?"). **[Research]** Rule: for social and marketing graphics, a relevant illustration that reinforces the message MAY be added; for analytical or decision-making charts, keep it minimal. Embellishment must never distort the data.

7.6 Infographics

- One story per infographic; 3–5 key points; a clear reading path (top to bottom or numbered).
- Use progressive disclosure: split across carousel slides rather than cramming.
- Icons and illustrations from one family (section 6.6).
- Every number sourced; every chart honest (7.3).

8. Copy and content inside the design

Edit the words before styling them: one message, a headline that states it, three to five scannable supporting points, one call to action, and every term, number and name checked against the source.

8.1 Message discipline

- **One primary message (MUST):** write it as a single sentence before designing. If you cannot, the brief is not ready.
- **One primary call to action (MUST when action is wanted):** secondary actions are visibly weaker.
- Classify every piece of copy as must-see, useful or optional. Optional copy goes to the caption, the next slide, or the bin.
- Word budget for a single social graphic: headline 3–10 words; up to 3–5 short supporting lines of 4–12 words each; footnote one line. More than about 40–50 words on one 1:1 graphic usually means it should be a carousel.

8.2 Headlines

- State the benefit, the finding or the tension (“Your land fees may have tripled”), not the category (“Land fee update”).
- Specific beats vague: numbers, names, places and dates.
- Front-load the key word; keep under about 60 characters for social.
- Questions work only when the viewer wants the answer.
- **MUST NOT** promise what the content does not deliver (clickbait erodes trust and may breach advertising codes).

8.3 Scannable structure

- Use parallel structure for lists (each item starts the same way grammatically, but not with the same word).
- Lead each bullet with its most informative word.
- Numbers as numerals (“5 things”), not words, in display copy.
- Plain language: short words, active voice, no jargon unless the audience uses it.

8.4 Terminology and local accuracy

- **Use the audience’s own professional and local terms.** Example: in Nigerian practice it is a **tenancy agreement**, not a lease, for most residential lets; “prevailing market rent of adjoining properties” is the valuer’s term, not “market rents nearby”.

- Use correct titles and post-nominals (ESV, MNIVS, RSV) exactly as the person uses them.
- Follow the client's spelling standard (UK English for Crea8Hub and most Nigerian professional work).
- Currency: ₦ symbol before the amount, no space (₦40 m or ₦40m, pick one and keep it); "m" for million, "bn" for billion.
- Dates: 9 November 2026 or 9 Nov 2026; never ambiguous 09/11/26 in public copy.

8.5 Calls to action

- Verb first, specific and low-friction: "Send me a message", "Book a valuation", "Swipe for details".
- Place where the reading path ends (bottom-right or bottom-centre for Z-pattern; last slide for carousels).
- Make it visually distinct (accent colour, button shape, or its own line) but not louder than the headline.

8.6 Proofreading protocol (MUST, every deliverable)

1. Read every word on the final export, not the draft, at 100% zoom.
2. Check names, titles, phone numbers, emails, URLs, handles, prices, dates, days of the week against the source.
3. Check numbers add up and match the caption and the post text.
4. Check spelling standard, capitalisation system, punctuation (curly quotes, en dashes).
5. Check every claim is supported and every statistic has a source (section 16).
6. Have a second person or a separate AI pass read it cold; the maker's eye skips errors.

9. Brand identity, logos and series consistency

A brand is recognised by a repeatable system (colour, type, layout, imagery, voice), not by the logo alone; protect the logo, codify the system in a guideline, and vary layouts within it so a series feels fresh but unmistakably related.

9.1 The identity system

Component	What to define
Logo suite	Primary, secondary (stacked/horizontal), icon or mark, monochrome and reversed versions

Component	What to define
Colour	Primary, secondary, accent, neutrals, with HEX, RGB, CMYK, Pantone, OKLCH (section 5.7)
Typography	Display and text families, weights, type scale, case rules
Layout	Grid, margins, recurring templates, label and button styles
Imagery	Photography style, grading, illustration style, icon family
Graphic devices	Shapes, patterns, dividers, frames that recur
Voice	Tone, spelling standard, words to use and avoid, hashtag limits
Motion	Easing, durations, logo animation, transitions (section 12)

9.2 Logo design principles

Henderson and Cote tested 195 logos and found that **natural** (recognisable, organic) and **harmonious** (balanced, symmetrical) designs with **moderate elaborateness** drive correct recognition and positive feeling; very simple and very complex marks both scored lower on affect (Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998). **[Research]**

Practice rules:

- **Simple enough to work at 16 px** (favicon, profile picture) and on a billboard.
- **Works in one colour** (black, white, single brand colour) before colour is added.
- **Distinctive** in its category; avoid clichés (house roofs for every estate firm, generic swooshes).
- **Timeless over trendy**; avoid effects (gradients, shadows) in the master mark.
- **Built on a construction grid** with consistent stroke weights and optical corrections.
- **Scales and reverses cleanly** (test on dark, light and photographic backgrounds).
- **Legally clear:** search for similar registered marks before adoption; register the trademark.

9.3 Logo usage rules (MUST)

- Clear space on all sides, usually defined by a part of the logo (e.g. the height of the letter x).

- Minimum size defined for screen (px) and print (mm).
- Never stretch, rotate, recolour outside approved versions, add effects, outline, or place on busy backgrounds without a container.
- One logo per composition is usually enough; repeating it weakens it.
- Respect partner and client logos: never redraw, recolour or crop them; use only supplied files.

9.4 Series consistency with variety

- **Fixed across a series:** palette, typefaces, type scale, label style, margins, icon family, image grading, logo placement.
- **Variable across a series:** layout template (split, full-bleed photo, typographic, comparison, carousel), dominant colour field, image subject, crop.
- Practical method: design 3–5 layout templates from the same system and rotate them so consecutive posts never share the same layout.
- **Carousels and multi-page pieces MUST share one layout** across all slides; variety comes between posts, not within one.
- **Cover test (MUST):** hide the logo; the piece should still be recognisably the brand.

9.5 About brand-consistency statistics

Claims such as “consistent branding increases revenue by 33%” come from a vendor survey of about 200 organisations by Lucidpress, a brand-template software company, with no published method for measuring revenue (PR Newswire, 2019). Treat as marketing, not evidence; the stronger argument for consistency is the fluency and mere-exposure research in section 1.2.

10. Accessibility and inclusive design

Meet WCAG 2.2 Level AA as the floor for everything digital: 4.5:1 text contrast, no meaning by colour alone, alt text on every informative image, captions on every video, no more than three flashes a second, and tap targets of at least 24 × 24 px. Accessible design is better design for everyone, including people reading a phone in Lagos sunlight.

10.1 WCAG 2.2 numbers designers must know

WCAG 2.2 became a W3C Recommendation on 5 October 2023 and added nine success criteria (W3C, What’s new in WCAG 2.2). **[Standard]**

Criterion	Level	Requirement
1.4.3 Contrast (Minimum)	AA	Text 4.5:1; large text (24 px, or 18.5 px bold) 3:1
1.4.6 Contrast (Enhanced)	AAA	Text 7:1; large text 4.5:1
1.4.11 Non-text Contrast	AA	Icons, chart parts, input borders, focus indicators 3:1
1.4.1 Use of Colour	A	Colour is never the only way information is conveyed
1.4.4 Resize Text	AA	Text can be enlarged to 200% without loss of content
1.4.12 Text Spacing	AA	Layout survives line height 1.5×, paragraph spacing 2×, letter spacing 0.12×, word spacing 0.16× font size
1.1.1 Non-text Content	A	Informative images have text alternatives
1.2.2 / 1.2.4 Captions	A / AA	Pre-recorded and live video has captions
2.2.2 Pause, Stop, Hide	A	Auto-moving content lasting over 5 s can be paused
2.3.1 Three Flashes	A	Nothing flashes more than three times in any one second (above threshold) (W3C)
2.5.8 Target Size (Minimum)	AA	Pointer targets at least 24 × 24 CSS px, or spaced so a 24 px circle fits
2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured	AA	Keyboard focus is never fully hidden
2.4.13 Focus Appearance	AAA	Focus indicator at least a 2 px perimeter with 3:1 change in contrast

10.2 Text alternatives (alt text)

- **Every informative image needs alt text (MUST)**, including social posts. LinkedIn supports alt text (“Alt text” under the image on desktop, “ALT” on mobile) and recommends under 120 characters; Instagram allows up to 1,000 (summary of platform API docs).
- Describe purpose and content, not appearance only: “Graphic: Lagos land fees may have tripled. New property values took effect 1 May 2026; Lekki Phase 1 consent rose from ₦12–18m to ₦40–90m (reported).”
- When an image contains text, the alt text must include that text.

- Decorative images get empty alt text (alt="") on the web.
- Do not start with “Image of”; screen readers already announce images.

10.3 Colour-vision deficiency

- About 1 in 20 Nigerian men has a colour-vision deficiency (section 5.6). Never rely on red vs green, or colour alone, for status, charts or required fields.
- Simulate deuteranopia, protanopia and tritanopia (Figma, Photoshop proof setups, Stark, Coblis) before approval.

10.4 Motion and seizure safety

- No more than three flashes per second; avoid large red flashes completely.
- Respect reduced-motion settings on the web (prefers-reduced-motion); offer static alternatives.
- Avoid parallax and large zoom effects that trigger vestibular discomfort, or make them subtle.

10.5 Cognitive accessibility

- Plain language, short sentences, one idea per line or slide.
- Consistent placement of navigation, labels and calls to action.
- Avoid time pressure, fake countdowns and auto-advancing content without controls.
- Use icons plus words, not icons alone.

10.6 Inclusive representation

- Show the audience as it is: ages, skin tones, body types, abilities, genders, religions and family types.
- Avoid stereotypes in roles (who is the boss, who serves, who cleans).
- Use inclusive, respectful language and correct names and titles.
- Test designs with real users from the target audience where stakes are high.

10.7 Real-world conditions

- Design for bright sunlight, low-end Android screens, cracked screens and low brightness: favour higher contrast than the minimum.
- Design for slow data: compress images and videos (section 19), keep text live (not baked into images) on websites.
- Test on a real mid-range phone at normal brightness before approval.

11. Platform and format specifications

Design for the destination: 1080 × 1350 px (4:5) is the strongest default for feed posts on Instagram and LinkedIn, 1080 × 1920 px (9:16) for Reels, TikTok, Stories, Shorts and WhatsApp Status, and every vertical video must keep text inside the platform's safe zone. Platforms change these often; re-check every quarter.

11.1 Feed and post sizes (checked November 2026)

Platform and format	Size (px)	Ratio	Notes
Instagram feed, portrait	1080 × 1350	4:5	Default; profile grid now previews at 3:4 and crops top and bottom slightly (Inro, Mar 2026)
Instagram feed, tall portrait	1080 × 1440	3:4	Matches the profile grid preview
Instagram square	1080 × 1080	1:1	Centred, symmetrical designs
Instagram carousel	1080 × 1350 every slide	4:5	All slides identical size
LinkedIn image, portrait	1080 × 1350	4:5	Takes the most space in the mobile feed (Contentin, 2026)
LinkedIn image, square	1080 × 1080	1:1	Safe alternative
LinkedIn document (carousel)	1080 × 1350 or 1080 × 1080 per page	4:5 or 1:1	PDF preferred; max 100 MB, 300 pages, one page size throughout
Reels, TikTok, Stories, YouTube Shorts, WhatsApp Status	1080 × 1920	9:16	See safe zones below
YouTube thumbnail	1280 × 720	16:9	Readable at 160 px wide
Presentation slide	1920 × 1080	16:9	4:3 only if the venue requires it
Email body	600–640 wide	—	Live text, not one big image
Website hero	1920–2560 wide	varies	Art-direct crops for mobile

Facebook and X sizes change frequently; check the platform's current help pages or the scheduling tool's preview before final export.

11.2 Safe zones on 1080 × 1920 vertical video

Platform buttons, captions and usernames cover parts of the frame. Values below are blocked margins in pixels (Adaptlypost, updated Oct 2026); interfaces change several times a year. **[Standard, unofficial]**

Platform	Top	Bottom	Left	Right
TikTok (organic)	108	320	60	120
TikTok (ads)	108	370	60	120
Instagram Reels	210	310	—	84
Instagram Stories	100–150	200–250	—	—
YouTube Shorts	120	300–360	—	96

Universal rule (MUST): keep all essential text, faces, logos and CTAs inside a centred **900 × 1400 px** area on a 1080 × 1920 canvas.

11.3 Feed post safe areas

- Instagram 4:5 posts: keep critical content out of the top and bottom ~45 px so the 3:4 grid crop does not cut it.
- LinkedIn and Instagram images: 60–80 px margin on every side at 1080 px width; extra room at the bottom of carousel pages for the page counter.
- Profile photos are shown as circles: keep the face within the central 70%.

11.4 Adapt, don't shrink

- When moving between ratios, re-compose: move the headline, re-crop the photo, re-flow text. Scaling a 1:1 design into 9:16 with bars above and below is a failure.
- Keep a master layout per ratio (1:1, 4:5, 9:16, 16:9) in the template set.
- Preview every final asset in the real platform (or a scheduler preview) before approval.

11.5 Text size on social, in practice

For a 1080 px wide graphic: headline 60–140 px, body 32 px or more, footnote at least 24 px, no more than about 30–40 words per slide. Below these, text becomes hard to read on phones (section 4.3).

12. Motion and video design

Assume the video is watched on a phone with the sound off: hook in the first 1–2 seconds, burn in accurate captions, keep text inside the safe zone and on screen long enough to read, and use motion only to direct attention.

12.1 Why captions and visual storytelling come first

In a Verizon Media and Publicis survey of 5,616 US adults (2019), **69%** watched video with the sound off in public, and **80%** of caption users were not deaf or hard of hearing (Streaming Media). **[Research, industry survey]** Captions are therefore required for reach, not only for accessibility (WCAG 1.2.2).

12.2 Structure of short-form video (Reels, TikTok, Shorts, Status)

1. **Hook (0–2 s):** the first frame alone must communicate the subject (a striking visual, a bold on-screen line, a question). Never open on a logo or a slow fade.
2. **Promise (2–5 s):** what the viewer will get.
3. **Payoff (body):** one idea per shot; change shot every 1.5–4 s for pace, slower for premium or emotional content.
4. **Close:** the takeaway and one call to action, held for at least 2 s.
5. **Cover frame:** design a separate thumbnail/cover that reads as a static post.

12.3 On-screen text

- Reading time: hold text at least **0.3 s per word plus 1 s** (a 6-word line needs about 3 s). Never flash text faster than it can be read.
- Maximum about 7 words per line, 2 lines per caption block.
- Captions: high-contrast (white with dark outline or box), sentence case, 48–64 px on a 1080 × 1920 frame, inside the safe zone (section 11.2).
- **MUST** proofread captions: auto-captions mishear names, numbers and Nigerian terms (Lekki, Ikoyi, ₦ amounts, Yoruba words).

12.4 Motion principles

Disney's 12 principles of animation, adapted to interfaces, remain the basis of motion craft: squash and stretch, anticipation, staging, straight-ahead vs pose-to-pose, follow-through, slow in and slow out (easing), arcs, secondary action, timing, exaggeration, solid drawing and appeal (UI/UX Atlas summary). **[Practice]**

Motion	Typical duration	Easing
Small UI elements (chips, toggles)	100–150 ms	ease-out entering
Mid-size (menus, cards)	150–250 ms	ease-out / ease-in-out
Full-screen transitions	250–400 ms	ease-in-out, e.g. cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)
Staggered list items	30–60 ms between items	—
Text reveal in social video	300–600 ms per element	ease-out
Logo sting / brand reveal	1–3 s total	brand-defined

- **Staging:** animate one thing at a time; motion is the strongest attention cue, so everything that moves competes.
- Elements that belong together move together (common fate, section 1.3).
- Enter with ease-out, exit with ease-in; never linear except for continuous loops.
- Consistent direction: if slides advance left, transitions always move left.

12.5 Video technical standards

Item	Standard
Vertical social	1080 × 1920, 9:16, 30 fps (25 fps acceptable), H.264 or H.265, AAC audio
Landscape	1920 × 1080 or 3840 × 2160, 16:9
Bitrate (1080p H.264)	8–12 Mbps for upload masters; platforms re-compress
Audio loudness	About −14 LUFS integrated for social and streaming; peaks below −1 dBTP

Item	Standard
Title-safe (broadcast)	Central 90% (action-safe) and 80% (title-safe)
Frame rate	Do not mix frame rates in one edit; 24 fps for cinematic, 30 for social, 60 for fast motion

12.6 Audio

- Use only licensed music: platform libraries, royalty-free libraries with commercial licences, or commissioned tracks. Trending sounds on personal accounts are often not cleared for brand or ad use (section 16).
- Voice clarity first: music ducked 12–20 dB under speech.
- Subtitle any speech; describe important sound effects in captions where meaningful.

12.7 Seizure and comfort safety

No more than three flashes per second (WCAG 2.3.1); avoid strobe and rapid red flashes; keep camera shake and zooms gentle (section 10.4).

13. Print production

A print file is ready only when it has 3 mm bleed, text at least 3–5 mm inside trim, images at 300 ppi at final size, CMYK colour within the press's ink limit, fonts embedded, and a signed-off proof. Screen-perfect designs routinely fail at the press on these points.

13.1 Core specifications

Parameter	Standard
Bleed	3 mm on every edge (some US printers use 0.125 in / 3.175 mm; large format may need 5–10 mm)
Safe zone	Text and key elements at least 3 mm inside trim; 5 mm is safer; booklets need more on the spine side
Resolution	300 ppi at final size for close viewing; 200–300 ppi for posters; 100–150 ppi large format; 25–72 ppi billboards
Total ink coverage	300% coated paper, 280% uncoated, 240% newsprint (confirm with the printer)
Rich black (large areas)	C60 M40 Y40 K100

Parameter	Standard
Text black	100% K only (no rich black on small text, it misregisters)
Hairlines	At least 0.25 pt (0.1 mm); reversed (white) text at least 8–9 pt, preferably bold

Values from a print file-prep reference (CMYK print guide); always confirm with the specific printer. **[Standard/Practice]**

13.2 Colour for print

- Work in CMYK with the printer's profile (e.g. FOGRA39/FOGRA51 coated, FOGRA52 uncoated in Europe; GRACoL/SWOP in the US; ask Nigerian printers which profile their press uses).
- Soft-proof RGB artwork before converting; bright RGB greens, blues and oranges shift.
- Specify **Pantone (spot) colours** for logos and brand colours that must match exactly, and give the CMYK build for four-colour jobs.
- Paper changes colour: uncoated stock prints darker and duller; show clients printed samples on the real stock.
- Metallics (gold, silver), foils, embossing and spot UV need separate spot-colour layers set to overprint, as the printer specifies.

13.3 File formats

- **PDF/X-4** is the modern default: supports live transparency, layers and colour-managed workflows, and moves easily between offset and digital presses. **PDF/X-1a** flattens everything to CMYK and is still requested by some older workflows (PDF Association). **[Standard: ISO 15930]**
- Embed or outline all fonts; include crop marks and bleed in the export.
- Keep native files (InDesign, Illustrator, Affinity, Figma) and linked images packaged for reprints.

13.4 Paper and finishing

Item	Typical choices
Flyers	130–170 gsm silk or gloss
Business cards	350–450 gsm, matt laminate or uncoated premium

Item	Typical choices
Posters	150–200 gsm, or 120 gsm blueback for outdoor
Brochures and booklets	130–170 gsm inners, 250–350 gsm covers; page count in multiples of 4
Invitations (e.g. weddings)	300–400 gsm textured or pearlescent; foil and emboss for premium
Outdoor (banners, signage)	PVC flex, mesh, vinyl; design at 1:10 scale at higher ppi if the printer allows

13.5 Proofing (MUST)

1. Digital proof checked against the preflight list in section 20.
2. Hard-copy proof for colour-critical work, on the real stock.
3. Written client sign-off on text, numbers and dates before production.
4. Check imposition, folds and binding (fold lines away from text; creep in thick booklets).

13.6 Large format and environmental graphics

- Legibility at distance: about 2.5 cm of cap height per 7–10 m of viewing distance (section 4.3).
- Signage needs high contrast, simple sans-serif type, and icons recognisable at a glance.
- Allow for hems, eyelets and pole pockets in banner artwork; keep text away from them.

14. UI, UX and web design essentials

Screens are used, not just viewed: design every component in all its states, make targets at least 44–48 px on touch screens, follow platform conventions, design mobile-first, and test with real users.

14.1 Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics (1994)

The standard checklist for reviewing any interface (The Decision Lab summary): **[Research/Practice]**

1. Visibility of system status
2. Match between the system and the real world

3. User control and freedom
4. Consistency and standards
5. Error prevention
6. Recognition rather than recall
7. Flexibility and efficiency of use
8. Aesthetic and minimalist design
9. Help users recognise, diagnose and recover from errors
10. Help and documentation

14.2 Touch and click targets

Standard	Minimum target
WCAG 2.2 SC 2.5.8 (AA)	24 × 24 CSS px, or enough spacing
Apple Human Interface Guidelines	44 × 44 pt
Google Material Design (Android)	48 × 48 dp

Use 44–48 px as the practical minimum on touch screens, with at least 8 px between adjacent targets. Place primary actions within thumb reach on phones (lower half of the screen). **[Standard]**

14.3 Component states (MUST design all)

Default, hover, focus (visible keyboard focus, section 10.1), active/pressed, disabled, loading, empty, error, success. Forms also need: placeholder vs label (labels always visible, never placeholder-only), helper text, validation messages next to the field.

14.4 Layout and responsiveness

- Mobile-first: design the smallest screen first, then expand.
- Common breakpoints: 360–480 px (phones), 768 px (tablets), 1024–1280 px (laptops), 1440 px+ (desktops).
- Columns: 4 on mobile, 8 on tablet, 12 on desktop; margins 16–24 px on mobile.
- Body text never below 16 px; line length 45–75 characters (section 4.5).
- Keep live text as HTML text, not images of text, for accessibility, search and translation.

14.5 Performance is design

- Pages should become usable quickly on mid-range Android phones and mobile data. Compress images (WebP/AVIF), lazy-load below-the-fold media, limit web fonts to 2–4 files.
- Google's Core Web Vitals (loading, interactivity, visual stability) are the common benchmark; layout must not jump as images load (reserve image space).

14.6 Ethical interface design: no dark patterns (MUST NOT)

Harry Brignull's catalogue of deceptive patterns (Piwik PRO summary) lists practices that manipulate users and that regulators increasingly penalise: **[Practice/Regulation]**

- **Confirmshaming** ("No thanks, I don't want to save money").
- **Hidden costs** revealed only at checkout.
- **Roach motel / forced continuity:** easy to subscribe, hard to cancel.
- **Disguised ads** that look like content or navigation.
- **Bait and switch** and **misdirection.**
- **Privacy zuckering:** tricking people into sharing more data than intended.
- **Fake urgency or scarcity:** countdown timers that reset, "only 2 left" when untrue.

14.7 Research and testing

- Five users in a usability test typically reveal most major problems in one round; test iteratively.
- Use the five-second test for landing pages and posts, first-click tests for navigation, and A/B tests for live performance (section 18).
- Design systems (tokens for colour, type, spacing, radius, elevation, motion) keep products consistent and are the digital equivalent of a brand guideline.

15. Cultural context and localisation

Design for the actual audience: local people, places, language, terms, calendars and symbols. In Nigeria that means correct professional terminology, the naira sign and local number conventions, respect for religious and ethnic diversity, and no national emblems in commercial work without authority.

15.1 Universal localisation rules

- **Reading direction:** left-to-right languages read F and Z patterns; right-to-left languages (Arabic, Ajami Hausa script) mirror the layout, including icons that imply direction.

- **Text expansion:** translations can run 20–35% longer than English; leave space in layouts.
- **Formats:** dates, times, currency, phone numbers and addresses follow local convention.
- **Imagery:** local people, dress, architecture, landscapes, light and climate.
- **Gestures and symbols** differ by culture; check hand gestures, animals, numbers and colours before using them.

15.2 Designing for Nigerian audiences

Area	Rule
Currency	₦ before the number (₦40,000; ₦40k; ₦40 m); check the font has the ₦ glyph
Professional terms	Use local practice: tenancy agreement (not lease) for most residential lets; Governor's Consent; C of O; survey plan; caution fee; agency and legal fees
Titles	Use titles people use: ESV, Arc., Engr., Barr., Dr, Chief, Alhaji/Alhaja, Pastor, HRM; get them exactly right
Language	English for professional work; Pidgin, Yoruba, Igbo or Hausa for warmth and reach where the brand voice allows; native speakers check every word and tone mark
Places	Name real neighbourhoods (Lekki, Ikoyi, Yaba, Wuse, GRA) to signal relevance; show recognisable local architecture
Calendar	Plan around Christmas, Easter, Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha (Sallah), Ramadan, Independence Day (1 Oct), Democracy Day (12 June), wedding seasons and school terms
Religion	Balance Christian and Muslim representation in general-audience work; avoid religious symbols in purely commercial contexts unless the client is faith-based
Ethnicity	Avoid ethnic stereotypes and jokes; represent the diversity of the audience

Area	Rule
Politics	Avoid party colours, slogans and figures in commercial work, especially in election periods
Connectivity	Many viewers use mid-range Android phones on mobile data: light files, high contrast, legible on small screens (section 10.7)

15.3 Colour and symbols

- See section 5.5: white (purity, holiness, some funerals), red (power, danger, passion), black (mourning), green and white (national identity).
- **National emblems (MUST NOT):** under section 6 of the Flags and Coats of Arms Act, using the National Flag or Coat of Arms, or close imitations, in connection with any business, trade or profession without authority is an offence (Laws of Nigeria). **[Law]** This applies to AI images too: a generated "official" crest on a land title or certificate must be removed.
- Do not reproduce government, NIESV, ESVARBON, bank or other institutional seals and logos unless the client is authorised to use them and supplies the files.

15.4 Representation in Nigerian contexts

- Show Nigerian professionals as competent experts in modern settings, not only in traditional or rural scenes.
- Reflect the real mix of ages, genders and regions of the audience.
- Traditional attire (aso-oke, agbada, isiagu, babban riga, gele) should be accurate to the culture shown and appropriate to the occasion.

16. Legal, ethical and regulatory rules

Only use assets you have the right to use, get consent from identifiable people, make no claim you cannot prove, disclose paid promotion, and in Nigeria get ARCON approval before an advert is published. This section is general guidance, not legal advice; confirm with a lawyer for high-stakes work.

16.1 Copyright and licensing

- **Assume everything is protected** unless you created it, licensed it, or it is clearly in the public domain. Nigeria's Copyright Act 2022 updated protection for the digital age, including digital copies and audio-visual works (Aluko & Oyebode summary).

- **Images:** use your own photography, properly licensed stock (keep the licence), commissioned work with a written assignment or licence, or AI output generated under terms that allow commercial use.
- **Fonts are software:** check the licence covers the use (desktop, web, app, broadcast, logo). Google Fonts are open licence; many commercial fonts need separate web or app licences.
- **Music:** commercial licences for brand and ad use (section 12.6).
- **Never** remove watermarks, crop out credits, or trace someone else's artwork, logo or character.

16.2 AI output and ownership

- In the US, the Copyright Office's January 2025 report concluded that prompts alone do not make a person the author: purely AI-generated output is not copyrightable, but human-authored elements and creative human selection, arrangement and modification can be (Jones Day, Feb 2025). **[Law/US]**
- Consequence: add meaningful human design work (layout, typography, edits) to AI imagery for anything that must be owned, such as a logo. **Never** use raw AI output as a trademark without legal advice.
- Do not prompt AI tools to imitate a living artist's distinctive style, a known character, or a brand's protected design.

16.3 People, likeness and privacy

- Get a signed model release from identifiable people in commercial work; property releases for private interiors and distinctive buildings where required.
- Nigeria's Data Protection Commission warned in March 2026 that filming or photographing people and sharing it without consent may breach privacy rights under the Constitution and the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023, and that creators can face prosecution (Arise News, 14 Mar 2026). **[Law/Nigeria]**
- **Never** create AI images, voices or deepfakes of real, identifiable people without written consent; never alter a real person's face in a headshot beyond normal retouching without their approval.

16.4 Advertising law and codes

- **ARCON (Nigeria):** adverts aimed at Nigerian consumers, including digital and influencer adverts, must be vetted and approved by ARCON's Standards Panel before exposure; publishing without approval is an offence, and brands and influencers can be jointly liable (Mondaq, May 2026). Build at least a week for approval into timelines. **[Law/Nigeria]**

- **Disclosure:** paid partnerships must be labelled; the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Act (s.126) prohibits misleading endorsements including undisclosed sponsorship (same source).
- **Truthful claims:** every factual claim, statistic, price, comparison and “before and after” must be true and provable; label estimates and reported figures as such; avoid unqualified superlatives (“best in Lagos”) without evidence.
- **Regulated sectors** (finance, health, property investment, alcohol, gambling, education) carry extra rules; for example, investment and returns claims need regulatory review.

16.5 Trademarks and third-party brands

- Do not use other companies’ logos or brand names in ways that imply endorsement or partnership that does not exist.
- Platform names and logos (LinkedIn, Instagram) follow the platform’s brand rules.
- National and institutional emblems: see section 15.3.

16.6 Ethics beyond the law

- No deceptive patterns (section 14.6) and no false urgency or scarcity.
- No body-shaming, colourism (skin-lightening edits), or stereotyping.
- Respect for the dead, the sick, and victims in news-related content; no exploitation of tragedy for promotion.
- When unsure whether something is acceptable, ask: would the audience feel misled or disrespected if they knew how this was made?

17. AI-generated design: guardrails

Treat every AI image as a fast junior designer’s draft: brief it precisely, change one thing at a time, assume it has invented something, and verify every word, number, logo and face before it ships. The person who publishes is accountable, not the model.

17.1 What AI should and should not do

Use AI for	Do not use AI (alone) for
Photographic scenes, backgrounds, textures, mood boards, concept options	Final logos and trademarks (not ownable, see 16.2)
Illustrations and visual metaphors	Charts and data graphics (values get invented; build them from data)

Use AI for	Do not use AI (alone) for
Layout explorations and variations	Legal, financial or medical documents and certificates
Retouching and extending your own photos (with care)	Images of real, identifiable people without consent
Short display headlines when checked	Long text, small print, tables, prices you cannot verify letter by letter
Generating options to choose from	Property, product or “before and after” images presented as real

17.2 The prompt brief (use for every generation)

OpenAI’s own guidance recommends ordering prompts as scene, subject, details, then constraints; putting literal text in quotes; spelling unusual words letter by letter; and stating exclusions and invariants explicitly (OpenAI image prompting guide).
[Standard/vendor] Use this template:

```
PURPOSE: LinkedIn feed post for [brand], audience [who], goal [one message]
FORMAT: 1080 x 1350 px (4:5), sRGB
LAYOUT: [e.g. navy panel left 50%, photo right 50%; margins 64 px]
PALETTE: dominant #14213D, background #F7F3EE, accent #F25C54 (accent only on
label and icons)
TYPE: bold geometric sans headline, regular sans body; sentence case; no more
than 2 weights
TEXT (exact, nothing else):
  Label: "LAGOS LAND FEES"
  Headline: "Your land fees may have tripled."
  Lines: "..." / "..." / "..."
  Footnote: "..."
IMAGE: [subject, setting, light, camera angle, local details]
CONSTRAINTS: no logos, no coats of arms or seals, no watermarks, no faces, no
extra text or numbers, no invented facts
CHECK: every word spelt exactly as given; all text inside a 64 px margin
```

17.3 Editing and iteration discipline

- **Change one thing per request** and say “change only X; keep layout, photo, colours, fonts, sizes and all other text exactly the same”. Repeat the preserve list every time; models drift.
- **Say what is approved** (“slide 3 is approved; do not regenerate it”) to stop silent re-generation.

- **Series:** generate one master, approve it, then ask for the others “in exactly the same layout, type sizes and margins as the approved image”. If one drifts, either fix it back or move the whole series to the new layout so all match.
- **When an edit changes facts or layout you did not ask for, reject it** and resend the exact text; never accept “close enough”.

17.4 Text in AI images

- An industry benchmark of 26 image models found that the best now render required text exactly, but weaker models drop words, add stray characters and invent punctuation; it recommends treating rendered text as a draft and keeping headlines as editable text layers where possible (IMG.LY benchmark). **[Research, vendor benchmark]**
- **Preferred workflow:** generate the image without text, then set the type in a design tool (Figma, Canva, Photoshop, Affinity) or as HTML/SVG. Text is then exact, editable, on-brand and translatable.
- **If text must be generated:** keep it short; quote it exactly; specify font style, size and position; zoom to 200% and check every character, especially digits, currency symbols (₦), apostrophes, dashes and tone-marked letters.
- **Small fixes:** correct a single malformed glyph by hand (clone a correct character from the same image) rather than regenerating and risking new errors.

17.5 Known failure modes and checks

Failure	Example	Check
Invented facts or numbers	Edit replaced “new property values took effect 1 May 2026” with made-up ground-rent figures	Compare every line against the approved copy
Malformed characters	“1” drawn as a reversed glyph; ₦ missing its bars	Zoom 200% on digits and symbols
Phantom emblems	Coat of arms, seals, crests, watermarks, fake app logos appear on documents and phones	Search the image for any mark you did not ask for
Layout drift	One carousel slide switches from angled panel to soft fade	Compare side by side with the master
Extra or missing text	A label repeated, a footnote dropped	Count text elements against the brief

Failure	Example	Check
Local inaccuracy	Western houses for a Lagos estate; wrong currency; wrong professional term	Check against the audience's real context (section 15)
Identity change	Headshot "improvement" alters the person's face	Side-by-side with the original; the person approves
Anatomy and physics	Extra fingers, warped hands, impossible reflections, melted text on signs	Inspect hands, faces, edges and backgrounds
Style imitation	Output resembles a known artist, character or brand	Reject and re-prompt without references to them
Misleading realism	A "photo" of a property that does not exist used to sell it	Never present AI scenes as the real asset

17.6 Verification protocol (MUST, before anything AI-made is published)

1. **Text audit:** every word, number and symbol matches the approved copy, letter by letter.
2. **Fact audit:** no claim, figure, date or name that is not in the brief.
3. **Mark audit:** no logos, seals, crests, watermarks, signatures or brand names that were not supplied.
4. **Consistency audit:** matches the approved master and the rest of the series.
5. **Guide audit:** passes section 20 (hierarchy, safe areas, contrast, type sizes).
6. **People audit:** no identifiable real person without consent; faces unchanged where they must be.
7. **Rights audit:** no imitation of protected styles, characters or brands.
8. **Disclosure audit:** labels and provenance in place where required (17.7).
9. **Second pair of eyes:** a human or separate AI review that has not seen the generation process.

17.7 Disclosure and provenance

- **Content Credentials (C2PA):** many AI tools embed provenance metadata; platforms such as LinkedIn read it and show a "CR" content-credentials label on AI-generated or AI-edited images. Do not strip this metadata to hide AI use.

- **EU AI Act Article 50** (applies from 2 August 2026): providers must mark AI outputs in machine-readable form; deployers must disclose deepfakes and AI-generated text published to inform the public, clearly and at first exposure; artistic and creative works get a lighter disclosure (AI Act guide). **[Law/EU]** Relevant whenever content reaches EU audiences.
- **Advertising:** realistic AI depictions of people, results or properties in adverts need clear disclosure and, in Nigeria, ARCON approval like any other advert (section 16.4).
- **House rule:** disclose AI use whenever a reasonable viewer would care, especially for realistic people, places and products.

17.8 Choosing the tool

- **Image models (ChatGPT image generation, Google Gemini/Imagen, Midjourney, Flux, Ideogram, Firefly):** best for photographic scenes and illustration; text quality varies by model and version, so always verify.
- **Layout-in-code (Claude and other assistants writing HTML, SVG or design-tool scripts):** exact text, exact brand colours and fonts, precise grids, easy edits; weaker at photographic realism. Combine: AI image for the photo, coded or design-tool layout for the type.
- **Design tools with AI (Canva, Adobe Express/Firefly, Figma):** good for templated series with brand kits and editable text.
- Prefer tools whose licence permits commercial use and that attach Content Credentials.

17.9 Standing instruction for AI design assistants

```
You are producing a design under the Complete Design Guide. Before
generating:
restate the objective, audience, format and exact text. Use only the text
supplied,
spelt exactly. Invent no facts, figures, names, logos, seals, coats of arms,
watermarks or brand marks. Keep all text inside the safe area and at or above
the
minimum sizes in section 4.3. Use the specified palette with 4.5:1 text
contrast.
When editing, change only what is requested and preserve everything else.
After
generating, run the section 17.6 verification protocol and report any line
that
does not match the brief instead of presenting the image as final.
```

18. Design process: brief to approval

Good design is a process: a written brief, research, several concepts, structured critique against the brief, controlled revisions, and measurement after launch. Skipping the brief is the most common cause of wasted rounds.

18.1 The Double Diamond

The UK Design Council's Double Diamond (2004) splits work into two rounds of opening up and narrowing down: **Discover** (understand the real problem), **Define** (frame the challenge), **Develop** (generate and co-create options), **Deliver** (test small, drop what fails, refine what works); the process loops back when findings demand it (Design Council). **[Practice/Standard]**

18.2 The creative brief (MUST before design starts)

Field	Example
Objective (one sentence)	Get Lagos landlords to see rent reviews need evidence, and message ESV Okunade
Audience	Landlords and tenants in Lagos, 30–60, on LinkedIn
Single message	A fair rent review starts with evidence
Deliverables and formats	1 LinkedIn image, 1080 × 1350 px; alt text; post copy
Mandatory content	Exact text, logos supplied, legal lines
Brand rules	Palette, fonts, tone, spelling standard, hashtag limits
Constraints	No faces; no logos; ARCON approval if it is an advert
References	Approved past posts, competitors, mood board
Deadline and approver	Date, named approver
Success measure	Saves, comments, profile visits, enquiries

18.3 Concepts and iteration

- Produce 2–3 genuinely different concepts at low fidelity before polishing one.
- Present each against the brief: how it delivers the message, not why you like it.

- Limit revision rounds in the contract (typically two or three); bundle feedback per round.
- One change at a time when working with AI (section 17.3).

18.4 Critique

Nielsen Norman Group's critique structure: the presenter restates objectives and asks for specific feedback; critiquers respond against those goals; a facilitator keeps scope and time; feedback is "conversation rather than command", framed as questions tied to goals rather than personal taste (NN/g). **[Practice]**

Useful feedback format: **observation** ("the headline and the photo compete") → **impact** ("the eye doesn't know where to start") → **suggestion or question** ("could the photo be darker so the headline leads?").

18.5 Versioning and file hygiene

- Name files: client_project_asset_size_version_date (e.g. medinat_rentreview_post_1080x1350_v03_2026-11-08.jpg).
- Keep approved masters separate from drafts; never overwrite an approved file.
- Record what changed in each version and who approved it.
- Delete superseded drafts and temporary files after delivery when the client asks for clean storage.

18.6 Testing and measurement

- **Before launch:** five-second test, thumbnail test, phone test, colleague cold read.
- **After launch:** compare like with like (same day and time, same format) on signal metrics: saves, shares, comments, profile visits, click-through, enquiries; not just likes.
- **A/B tests:** change one variable (headline, image, layout) at a time; wait for enough impressions before calling a winner.
- Feed results back into templates and this guide.

19. File preparation and delivery

Export each asset in the format its destination needs, at the exact size, in the right colour space, compressed without visible loss, named consistently, and delivered with its editable source and any licences.

19.1 Choosing the format

Format	Use for	Avoid for
JPG	Photographs and photo-heavy social posts (quality 80–92%)	Text-heavy graphics with flat colour (artefacts around letters)
PNG	Graphics with text, flat colour, transparency, screenshots	Large photos (heavy files)
WebP / AVIF	Website images (smaller than JPG/PNG at the same quality)	Platforms that don't accept them; print
SVG	Logos, icons, illustrations on the web	Photographs
PDF	Print (PDF/X-4), documents, LinkedIn document carousels	Social single-image posts
MP4 (H.264/H.265)	Video for all social platforms	—
GIF	Avoid; use MP4 or animated WebP instead	Anything with many colours
Vector source (AI, EPS, SVG, PDF)	Logo masters and handover	—

19.2 Export checklist

- Exact pixel size for the platform (section 11); export at 1× the canvas for social (platforms re-compress larger files anyway), 2× for websites on high-density screens.
- **sRGB** embedded for screen; printer's CMYK profile for print.
- Social image under about 1–5 MB; website images usually under 200–500 KB; LinkedIn documents under 100 MB.
- Text-heavy social graphics: export PNG or high-quality JPG (90%+), then check letters at 100% for halos and blocking.
- Remove hidden layers, off-canvas elements and personal metadata you don't want shared (but keep Content Credentials, section 17.7).
- Check the export file, not the working file, against section 20.

19.3 Naming and organisation

- Pattern: client_project_asset_dimensions_version_date (section 18.5).

- One folder per project: /source, /exports, /assets (licensed images, fonts), /approved, /archive.
- Keep the approved master and its exports together; mark them clearly as APPROVED.

19.4 Handover package

- Final exports in every required size and format.
- Editable source files (Figma, Canva link, PSD, AI, INDD, Affinity) with linked assets packaged.
- Fonts list with licence status (never send font files the licence doesn't allow to be shared).
- Image and music licences, model and property releases.
- Alt text and post copy for every social asset.
- A short usage note: where each asset goes, posting dates, what needs regulatory approval (ARCON) before use.

19.5 Storage hygiene

- Delete temporary files, relays, test exports and superseded drafts once the client approves, if requested.
- Back up approved masters in at least two places.
- Never store client personal data (CVs, IDs, contracts) in shared design folders longer than needed.

20. Quality control: scoring and pre-flight checklists

A design is approved only when it has no critical failure and scores at least 8/10 in every category; a high average never rescues a failure in accuracy, legibility, hierarchy, accessibility, rights or brand. Run the relevant checklist on the exported file.

20.1 Critical failures (any one = revise, whatever the score)

1. Any wrong word, number, name, date, price or contact detail.
2. Any invented fact, logo, seal, coat of arms or watermark (AI or otherwise).
3. Text below the minimum size for the medium (section 4.3) or contrast below 4.5:1 (3:1 large text).
4. No clear focal point or reading order.
5. Essential content outside the safe area or cut by the platform crop.
6. Meaning carried by colour alone.
7. Rights not cleared (images, fonts, music, people's likeness).

8. Off-brand palette, type or logo misuse.
9. Missing required disclosure or regulatory approval (paid partnership, AI realism, ARCON).
10. Inconsistent layout within a carousel or multi-page piece.

20.2 Scoring rubric (0–10 each; minimum 8 to pass)

Category	10/10 looks like
Objective	The one message is understood in 5 seconds
Hierarchy	Clear first, second, third read; survives the blur test
Composition	Grid-based, balanced, deliberate whitespace, no tangencies
Typography	One or two families, systematic scale, correct sizes, good line breaks
Colour	Controlled palette, 60/30/10-style dominance, functional accent
Contrast and accessibility	WCAG AA met; colour-blind safe; alt text and captions ready
Imagery	Relevant, sharp, consistent treatment, purposeful crop, locally accurate
Content accuracy	Every word, figure and term correct and sourced
Brand	Recognisably on-brand with the logo covered
Series consistency and variety	Matches its set; varies from the previous post
Platform fit	Correct size, safe zones, survives the feed at phone size
CTA	The next action is obvious and singular
Professional finish	No artefacts, misalignments, widows, typos or export damage
Compliance and ethics	Rights cleared, disclosures in place, no deceptive patterns

20.3 Universal pre-flight (every asset)

- The objective fits in one sentence, and the design delivers it.
- One unmistakable focal point; reading order is obvious.
- All text proofread letter by letter on the export (section 8.6).
- Type sizes at or above the medium minimums; line lengths and leading comfortable.
- Contrast checked with a tool; grayscale test passed.
- Everything aligned to a grid; margins and safe areas respected.
- Related items grouped; unrelated items separated.
- Palette and fonts match the brand; logo used correctly (or absent by design).
- Images sharp at 100%, cropped with purpose, rights cleared.
- Icons from one family; no decoration without function.
- No tangencies, near-misses, orphans or widows.
- Checked at actual size, at thumbnail size and on a phone.

20.4 Extra checks by format

Social single image

- Correct canvas (1080 × 1350 or 1080 × 1080) and 64–80 px margins.
- Headline 60 px+, body 32 px+, footnote 24 px+ at 1080 px width.
- Instagram 3:4 grid crop does not cut content; LinkedIn preview checked.
- Alt text written; post copy uses the same terms and numbers as the image.

Carousel or document

- Slide 1 works alone as a hook; last slide carries the CTA.
- Identical layout, type sizes, margins and label style on every slide; page indicators consistent.
- PDF has one page size throughout and is under 100 MB.

Video and motion

- Hook in the first 2 seconds; cover frame designed.
- Captions burned in, proofread, inside the 900 × 1400 px safe area.
- Text holds at least 0.3 s per word + 1 s; no more than three flashes per second.
- Licensed music; loudness about −14 LUFS.

Print

- 3 mm bleed, 3–5 mm safe zone, crop marks.
- 300 ppi images at final size; CMYK with the printer’s profile; ink limit respected.

- Small text in 100% K; fonts embedded; PDF/X-4.
- Hard proof and written sign-off for colour-critical or high-volume jobs.

Web and UI

- All component states designed; targets 44–48 px on touch.
- Body text 16 px+; responsive at 360, 768, 1280 px.
- Images compressed (WebP/AVIF); no layout shift.
- Keyboard focus visible; no deceptive patterns.

AI-generated or AI-edited

- Section 17.6 verification protocol complete and recorded.
- No phantom marks, invented facts or identity changes.
- Disclosure decided and Content Credentials kept.

20.5 Final sign-off

Approved by (name), on (date), for (platform and placement), with ARCON approval number if an advert. Store the approved file in the APPROVED folder (section 19.3).

21. Glossary and sources

21.1 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Baseline grid	Horizontal lines all text sits on, keeping columns aligned
Bleed	Artwork extending past the trim so no white edge appears after cutting
C2PA / Content Credentials	Open standard for provenance metadata showing how an image was made or edited
CMYK / RGB	Ink (subtractive) and light (additive) colour models
Critical print size	Smallest text size at which reading reaches full speed
Figure–ground	Separation of an object from its background
Gutter	Space between columns

Term	Meaning
Kerning / tracking	Space between a specific pair of letters / across a whole word or line
Leading	Distance between lines of text
Measure	Line length, usually counted in characters
OKLCH	Perceptually uniform colour space: lightness, chroma, hue
Orphan / widow	A lone word or line stranded at a line, column or page break
Processing fluency	Ease with which something is perceived; drives liking and trust
Prototypicality	How typical a design looks for its category
Safe zone	Area free of platform overlays and crop risk
Scrim	Semi-transparent layer behind text to raise contrast on images
Tangency	Two edges almost touching, creating visual tension
Type scale	Fixed set of sizes in a consistent ratio
Visual weight	How strongly an element pulls the eye
WCAG	Web Content Accessibility Guidelines, the international accessibility standard
x-height	Height of lowercase letters; drives apparent size and legibility

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- Vertical video safe zones 2026 (Adaptlypost)
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